

The Design— —System Checklist

A phased checklist for building a new design system from scratch. Comprehensive scope (web, mobile, brand). Tooling-agnostic. Audience: cross-functional teams. This document was created following the talk by Karen Segev and Ido Zaifman Co-founder [Kido](#) at DesignAi7 Conference on May 11,2026 . It was made with ♥ .

[Appendix - Checklist birdseye-view](#)

Disclaimer

This checklist is a general reference framework distilled from dozens of enterprise design system implementations — not a one-size-fits-all blueprint. Every organization has its own context, and applying it as is usually leads to wasted effort or low adoption. To use it effectively, partner with a Design System specialist who can sequence the work against your constraints and decide what's genuinely required. Treat this document as a starting point for that conversation, not a substitute for it.

About Kido | wearekido.com

The Kido team comprises experienced professionals across multiple disciplines, including senior product designers specializing in product experience and brand design, full-stack developers with a frontend focus, design system leads, and motion designers (as needed). This diverse and specialized team is equipped to support all aspects of design system development—from strategy and design to implementation and governance. We bring 15+ years of enterprise-grade expertise in building scalable complex design solutions & design-to-development infrastructure.

Our Unique Position

- **The only Israeli agency** with DesignOps as core specialization
- **Official Figma Israel community** founders and leaders
- **Figma exclusive partner track** - in progress
- **8+ years deep DS & Figma expertise** across 40+ enterprise implementations
- **Full design-to-development capability** with in-house developers

How to use this checklist

1. **Scope it down.** Don't try to ship MVP across all five categories simultaneously, pick the categories that matter most for your context.
2. **Phase honestly.** Marking something MVP doesn't mean rushing it, it means it's required before you call the system v1.0.
3. **Re-audit.** Treat Section 5 as a self-check even for systems you built yourself.

Phasing key

[MVP] - required to ship v1.0 and call it a design system

[v1] - required for adoption, scale, and credibility within 6–12 months

[v2] - maturity, governance, and long-term resilience

1. Foundation

The non-negotiable primitives. If these are wrong, every component built on top inherits the problem.

1.1 Brand alignment [MVP]

Item: Document the relationship between brand identity and product UI.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ A written statement defines what the design system inherits from brand (logo, voice, color inheritance) and where product UI deviates and why.
- ☐ Sign-off from both brand owner and design system lead.

1.2 Design principles [MVP]

Item: 3–7 written principles that guide design decisions.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Each principle is actionable (a designer can use it to choose between two options) and includes a “do / don’t” example.

1.3 Color tokens [MVP]

Item: Two-tier color token system (primitive → semantic).

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Primitive palette is documented with values in HEX, RGB, and/or HSL.
- ☐ Semantic tokens (e.g., surface/primary, text/danger) reference primitives, never raw values.
- ☐ All foreground/background pairs in semantic tokens meet WCAG AA contrast (4.5:1 for body, 3:1 for large text and UI).

1.4 Typography tokens [MVP]

Item: Type scale, font families, weights, and line-heights as tokens.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Defined scale (e.g., 6–10 steps) with semantic names (heading/lg, body/md).
- ☐ Fallback stacks specified for each font family.
- ☐ Line-height and Font-sizes values in rem, not px.

1.5 Spacing & layout tokens [MVP]

Item: A spacing scale and layout grid system.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ A spacing scale has a documented base unit (e.g., 4px) and named steps.
- ☐ Grid breakpoints documented at least for Mobile, Tablet and Desktop.
- ☐ Negative space rules and container max-widths defined.

1.6 Iconography [MVP]

Item: A consistent icon library with usage rules.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Defined grid (e.g., 24×24), stroke weight, and corner radius rules.
- ☐ Minimum starter set (≥30 icons) covering common UI actions.
- ☐ Format strategy documented (SVG sprites, icon font, or per-platform).

1.7 Theming architecture [v1]

Item: Token structure that supports light, dark, and brand themes.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Token naming separates “what it is” (primitive) from “how it’s used” (semantic).
- ☐ At least light + dark themes shipped and verified for contrast.
- ☐ Documented process to add a new theme without touching components.

1.8 Motion tokens [v1]

Item: Duration, easing, and motion-pattern tokens.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Standard durations (e.g., motion/fast, motion/base, motion/slow).
- ☐ Easing curves named and documented.
- ☐ prefers-reduced-motion strategy specified.

1.9 Elevation & depth [v1]

Item: Tokens for shadow, blur, and z-index layering.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Elevation tokens map to semantic uses (resting card, modal, popover, toast).

- ☐ Z-index scale prevents stacking conflicts (named layers, not magic numbers).

1.10 Cross-platform parity [v2]

Item: Token translation pipeline across web, iOS, Android.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Single source of truth (e.g., a tokens repo) outputs platform-specific formats.
- ☐ Drift detection between platforms.

1.11 Internationalization foundations [v2]

Item: Tokens and primitives that survive RTL, multi-language, and locale shifts.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Logical properties used over physical ones (start/end vs. left/right).
- ☐ Type scale tested with Hebrew, Arabic, CJK, and long German strings.

2. Components

The building blocks consumers actually touch. Each component must be predictable, accessible, and documented.

2.1 Component inventory & roadmap [MVP]

Item: Prioritized list of components scoped for MVP, v1, v2.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Inventory mapped to real product surfaces and pain points.
- ☐ Each component has a defined owner and a target release.

2.2 MVP component set [MVP]

Item: Ship the core 12–20 components that teams will need for building the typical screens.

Acceptance criteria: Includes at minimum:

- ☐ Button
- ☐ Input
- ☐ Select Input
- ☐ Checkbox
- ☐ Radio Button
- ☐ Toggle
- ☐ Card
- ☐ Modal
- ☐ Toast
- ☐ Tooltip
- ☐ Tabs
- ☐ Avatar
- ☐ Badge
- ☐ Link
- ☐ Menu
- ☐ Each ship in both design and code, with parity verified.

2.3 Component anatomy [MVP]

Item: Every component has a documented anatomy and prop/variant model.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ All slots, regions, and props labeled in the design source.
- ☐ Variants and states are exhaustive (default, hover, focus, active, disabled, loading, error).

2.4 Accessibility per component (WCAG 2.2 AA) [MVP]

Item: Each component meets WCAG 2.2 AA before release.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Keyboard operability verified (tab order, focus traps, escape behavior).
- ☐ Screen reader behavior tested in at least two readers (NVDA + VoiceOver).
- ☐ ARIA roles, names, and states documented.
- ☐ Focus visible meets 3:1 contrast against adjacent colors.
- ☐ Hit targets $\geq 24 \times 24$ CSS px (AA) or $\geq 44 \times 44$ (mobile preferred).

2.5 Responsive behavior [MVP]

Item: Documented responsive behavior per component.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Each component specifies behavior at each defined breakpoint.
- ☐ Define breakpoints for each supporting platform.
- ☐ Touch vs. pointer differences explicit.

2.6 Component library code parity [MVP]

Item: Code components match design components 1:1.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Same props, same variant names, same states.
- ☐ Visual regression tests in place for the MVP set.

2.7 Pattern library [v1]

Item: Documented patterns assembled from components (forms, empty states, data tables, navigation, dialogs).

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Each pattern includes when to use, when not to use, and a working example.
- ☐ Pattern usage doesn't require designers to re-invent the underlying components.

2.8 Form & validation patterns [\[v1\]](#)

Item: Standard patterns for form layout, error messaging, and validation.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Inline error, summary error, success, and async-validation patterns documented.
- ☐ Accessible error association (aria-describedby, aria-invalid) demonstrated.

2.9 Data visualization primitives [\[v1\]](#)

Item: Chart and data-display primitives aligned with token system.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Chart color palette is colorblind-safe and documented.
- ☐ Empty, loading, and error states defined for data displays.

2.10 Composite & domain components [\[v2\]](#)

Item: Higher-order components serving specific product domains.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Built only on top of foundational components, never bypassing tokens.
- ☐ Owned by a domain team but reviewed by the Design System team.

3. Documentation

Documentation is the product. Components nobody can find or understand are not adopted.

3.1 Documentation site [MVP]

Item: A single, searchable home for the design system.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Available to all consumers (designers, devs, PMs) via one URL.
- ☐ Search returns relevant results for common terms (e.g., "button", "color").

3.2 Getting started guide [MVP]

Item: A path from "I just heard about this" to "I built something" in under 30 minutes.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Separate quickstarts for designers (Figma library install) and developers (package install).

3.3 Per-component docs [MVP]

Item: Each component has a standardized doc page.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Includes: overview, anatomy, props/variants, states, accessibility notes, do/don't, code example, design example.

3.4 Token documentation [MVP]

Item: Every token is discoverable with name, value, and usage context.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Searchable token reference (color, type, spacing, motion, elevation).
- ☐ For each token: example usage and which components consume it.

3.5 Accessibility guidance [MVP]

Item: Cross-cutting accessibility documentation beyond per-component notes.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Covers focus management, keyboard patterns, screen reader testing, color/contrast.

- ☐ Linked from every component page.

3.6 Content & voice guidelines [v2]

Item: UX writing rules covering tone, terminology, error messages, capitalization.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Glossary of preferred terms.
- ☐ Examples for buttons, empty states, errors, confirmations.

3.8 Changelog & release notes [v1]

Item: Human-readable record of every release.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Categorized by added / changed / deprecated / removed / fixed.
- ☐ Breaking changes flagged with migration guidance.

3.9 AI-readable documentation [v1]

Item: Documentation structured to be parsed by LLMs and AI assistants.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Component and token docs available as clean markdown (not just HTML).
- ☐ Each component page has machine-readable metadata: props schema, variants, accessibility requirements, usage rules.
- ☐ A consolidated llms.txt or equivalent index exists at the doc-site root.

3.10 MCP server / programmatic access [v2]

Item: AI tools can query the design system for tokens, components, and rules.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ An MCP server (or equivalent API) exposes tokens, component metadata, and usage examples.
- ☐ Documented prompts and example AI workflows for designers and developers.

4. Maintenance & Governance

A design system that ships once and never evolves becomes legacy. Governance is how it stays alive.

4.1 Ownership & operating model [MVP]

Item: A named team (or individual) owns the design system.

Acceptance criteria:

The operating model is one of the following - and is explicitly named

- ☐ Centralized
- ☐ Federated
- ☐ Hybrid

- ☐ The team has dedicated time, not 20% headcount.

4.2 Versioning strategy [MVP]

Item: Semantic versioning applied to design and code libraries.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ MAJOR / MINOR / PATCH meaning is documented.
- ☐ Design library versions are tracked alongside code versions.

4.3 Release process [MVP]

Item: A repeatable release workflow.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Defined cadence (e.g., bi-weekly minor, ad-hoc patch, scheduled major).
- ☐ Pre-release checklist covers tests, visual regression, docs, changelog, communication.
- ☐ Release announcement reaches all consumer teams (e.g., a release channel).

4.4 Deprecation policy [MVP]

Item: A clear path for removing components, tokens, or props.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Minimum deprecation window defined (e.g., 1-2 minor versions before removal).
- ☐ Deprecations are flagged in code (warnings) and docs.

- ☐ Migration guide accompanies every deprecation.

4.5 Contribution model [MVP]

Item: A documented way for outside contributors to propose and submit changes.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ A CONTRIBUTING.md (or equivalent) explains the process end-to-end.
- ☐ Templates for: bug reports, new component proposals, token requests, doc fixes.
- ☐ Definition of Done published (covers code, design, docs, tests, accessibility).
- ☐ Review SLAs are stated (e.g. initial response within 3 business days).

4.6 Intake & triage [v1]

Item: A predictable way to receive and prioritize requests.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Single intake channel (form, board, or repo issues).
- ☐ Triage cadence defined and held (e.g., weekly).
- ☐ The public roadmap reflects accepted requests.

4.7 Cross-functional rituals [v1]

Item: Standing meetings or async ceremonies that keep stakeholders aligned.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ At minimum: a recurring office hours, a release review, and a quarterly roadmap review.
- ☐ Designers, developers, PMs, and accessibility specialists all have a representation channel.

4.8 Support model [v1]

Item: Defined channels for help and known response expectations.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Tier 1 (self-serve docs), Tier 2 (community channel), Tier 3 (direct team support) clearly mapped.
- ☐ Response-time expectations published.

4.9 Funding & success metrics [v2]

Item: A funding model and metrics that prove value.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Adoption tracked (% of products using the system, % of components on latest version).
- ☐ Quality tracked (accessibility violations, time-to-fix, support volume).
- ☐ Efficiency tracked (time saved per project, design/dev parity rate).
- ☐ Reported to leadership on a regular cadence.

4.10 Roadmap transparency [v2]

Item: A public, current, and trusted roadmap.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Roadmap shows now / next / later (or equivalent).
- ☐ Updated after every triage cycle.

5. Audit (Evaluating an Existing System)

Use this section when the goal is to assess a design system that already exists.

5.1 Foundation audit [MVP]

Item: Assess whether tokens and primitives are coherent, complete, and consistently used.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Token inventory exported; orphans (defined but unused) and gaps (used but undefined) listed.
- ☐ Hardcoded values found in design files and codebase are quantified.
- ☐ Theming architecture evaluated for ability to support new themes without component changes.

5.2 Component audit [MVP]

Item: Assess coverage, consistency, and accessibility of the component library.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Inventory of components in design source vs. code (drift % reported).
- ☐ Sample of 10+ components evaluated against a defined component-quality rubric.
- ☐ WCAG 2.2 AA conformance checked for top-used components, violations logged with severity.

5.3 Documentation audit [MVP]

Item: Assess whether documentation enables self-serve adoption.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Coverage map: which components/tokens have docs, which don't.
- ☐ Freshness check: % of docs last updated within 6 months.
- ☐ Findability test: 5 sample queries reviewer rates whether the answer is reachable in under 60 seconds.

5.4 Governance audit [v1]

Item: Assess whether the operating model is real, not aspirational.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Ownership clarity confirmed (who decides? who funds?).
- ☐ Last 3 releases reviewed for changelog, migration guidance, and announcement.

- ☐ Contribution model tested: time from "outside contributor opens issue" to first response.

5.5 Adoption audit [v1]

Item: Measure real adoption across products.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ % of screens using design system components (sampled or instrumented).
- ☐ % of teams on latest major version.
- ☐ List of "rogue" components: local re-implementations of system components, quantified per product.

5.6 Cross-platform consistency audit [v2]

Item: Assess parity between web, iOS, Android, and any other platforms.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Same component compared across platforms; visual and behavioral deltas listed.
- ☐ Token drift between platforms quantified.

5.7 AI-readiness audit [v2]

Item: Assess whether the system is usable by AI tools and assistants.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Documentation tested via LLM retrieval: does the model return accurate component usage when prompted?
- ☐ Machine-readable assets (token JSON, component schemas, llms.txt) inventoried.

5.9 Audit deliverable [MVP]

Item: A consolidated audit report with prioritized findings.

Acceptance criteria:

- ☐ Findings grouped by category (foundation, components, docs, governance, adoption, accessibility).
- ☐ Each finding has: severity, evidence, recommendation, estimated effort.

Design System Checklist

A phased framework for building, evaluating, and governing design systems from foundation to AI-readiness.

54

checklist items across 5 categories

Phasing: **MVP** v1 v2

01 Foundation

11 items

Tokens & primitives that everything inherits from

SAMPLE ITEMS

- Color tokens (WCAG AA)
- Typography scale
- Spacing & layout
- Theming architecture
- i18n & RTL

02 Components

11 items

The building blocks teams actually touch

SAMPLE ITEMS

- MVP set (12–20)
- Component anatomy
- WCAG 2.2 AA per component
- Code 🧑‍💻 design parity
- Patterns & forms

03 Documentation

11 items

The context layer for building by human or agents

SAMPLE ITEMS

- Doc site & search
- Per-component pages
- Token reference
- AI-readable docs
- MCP / programmatic API

04 Governance

11 items

How the system stays alive & evolving after launch

SAMPLE ITEMS

- Ownership model
- Versioning & releases
- Deprecation policy
- Contribution model
- Quality gates

05 Audit

09 items

Evaluating an existing system

SAMPLE ITEMS

- Token & component drift
- Doc coverage & freshness
- Adoption metrics
- Accessibility scan
- AI-readiness audit

Checklist by the Kido team | MD Files recreated with ❤️ & Claude